

THE RESEARCH BEHIND THE BOOTH

What the science actually says about *SOS meditation*

If you picked up a card or scanned a QR code at our VeggieFest booth, this is the page it points to. Below are the six studies on our posters — what each one found, where it was published, and links to read the original papers yourself.

SOS meditation is a simple practice: sit quietly, eyes closed, attention turned inward, silently repeating a calming word for about ten minutes a day. In older research it appears under its earlier name, *Jyoti meditation* — the same practice.



HOW TO READ THESE RESULTS

Two of these studies are **randomized trials**, which can support cause-and-effect language. Others are **comparisons between people who already meditate and people who don't** — those show associations, not proof that meditation caused the difference. Two are **still in progress or under peer review**. We've labelled every study so you can weigh it accordingly.

The six studies on our posters

Each poster at the booth covers one study. Links go to the published paper where one exists.

PUBLISHED Frontiers in Psychiatry, 2025 • Hindu College, University of Delhi

Meditation and stress during India's COVID lockdown

77% of meditators vs. 40% of non-meditators said their well-being held steady

148 undergraduates were surveyed during India's 2020 lockdown. Regular SOS meditators were far more likely to report that lockdown hadn't shaken their mental and emotional well-being, and reported lower stress scores. Students who practised more often reported less stress.

Cross-sectional comparison, not a trial — meditators chose to practise, so this shows an association rather than proof of cause.

[Read the paper](#)

[Poster \(PDF\)](#)

PREPRINT • UNDER REVIEW medRxiv, 2026 • Stanford University

A fully remote randomized trial of ten minutes a day

299 adults • 10 minutes daily • 8 weeks — and the gains lasted

A registered randomized controlled trial (NCT06014281) with a waitlist control and a crossover phase. Anxiety and mind-wandering fell for whichever group was meditating, the pattern repeated when the waitlist group began, and improvements were still present eight weeks after daily practice stopped. Perceived stress, rumination, depressive symptoms, social connectedness and quality of life also improved.

Not yet peer-reviewed. Sleep, cognitive-task and heart-rate findings appeared only in specific subgroups.

[Read the preprint](#)

[Trial registration](#)

[Poster \(PDF\)](#)

PUBLISHED The Journal of Pain, 2015 • Charité – Universitätsmedizin Berlin

Chronic neck pain and psychological distress

Pain at rest fell 52% with meditation vs. 14% with home exercise

89 patients who had lived with chronic neck pain for an average of eleven years were randomized to eight weeks of meditation or a home neck-exercise programme. Pain at rest dropped sharply in the meditation group, and patients also reported being less bothered by their pain day to day.

Randomized but unblinded; 38% did not complete follow-up. No significant group difference in pain during movement, mood scores or quality of life. Published when the practice was called Jyoti meditation.

[Read the paper](#)

[Poster \(PDF\)](#)

PUBLISHED Counselor Education & Supervision, 2016 • UNC Charlotte & University of Central Florida

Stress in graduate counselling students

Students who practised daily cut their perceived stress by about a quarter

60 master's-level counselling students were randomized to six weeks of meditation or a communication-skills comparison group. Among those who actually practised at least ten minutes a day at home, stress dropped substantially while the comparison group stayed flat. Students with higher emotional intelligence at the start benefited more.

The headline effect is for the 20 students who practised daily; across all 60 participants the group difference did not reach statistical significance. Published as Jyoti meditation.

[Read the paper](#)

[Poster \(PDF\)](#)

SUBMITTED • UNDER REVIEW Spirituality in Mental Health • University of Central Florida and partners

Long-term meditators compared with non-meditators

Lower stress, lower depression, greater sense of meaning in life

75 people with years of SOS practice were surveyed alongside 67 non-meditators. The experienced meditators scored significantly lower on stress and depression and reported a stronger sense that their life has meaning.

Cross-sectional and self-selected — this cannot show that meditation caused the difference. No group difference in rumination or in actively searching for meaning. Manuscript under peer review; details may change.

[Paper not yet available](#)

[Poster \(PDF\)](#)

PRELIMINARY • ANALYSIS IN PROGRESS

University of Central Florida, Johns Hopkins & Virginia Commonwealth University

Meditation for women living with breast cancer

Hope rose more with meditation; stress eased within the meditation group

A randomized trial with 78 women in treatment for breast cancer or in survivorship, comparing six weeks of SOS meditation with a waitlist. Hope showed the clearest benefit for the meditation group, and stress fell significantly within that group over the study.

Preliminary and not yet peer-reviewed; submission expected in 2026. Depression eased in both groups equally and heart-rate variability showed no systematic difference. This is not a treatment recommendation — please discuss supportive practices with your care team.

[Paper in preparation](#)

[Poster \(PDF\)](#)

Questions about the research, or want to talk to one of the authors? Come find us at the IMIH booth at VeggieFest, or write to research@imih.org.

Study summaries on this page are plain-language descriptions written for a general audience. Where a study is a comparison rather than a randomized trial, or is not yet peer-reviewed, we have said so on the card. For exact methods, effect sizes and limitations, please read the original papers.